



What the Tally Never Asked

An interview study of how supervisors notice a lonely child, against what the tally reports

Dagny Okafor · Ingeborg Nwachukwu — School of Continuous Improvement

Background

An end-of-term inclusion report increasingly cites a buddy-bench uptake tally as evidence a school is reaching lonely children. Whether the tally has anything to do with how a supervisor actually notices one is untested.

Aims

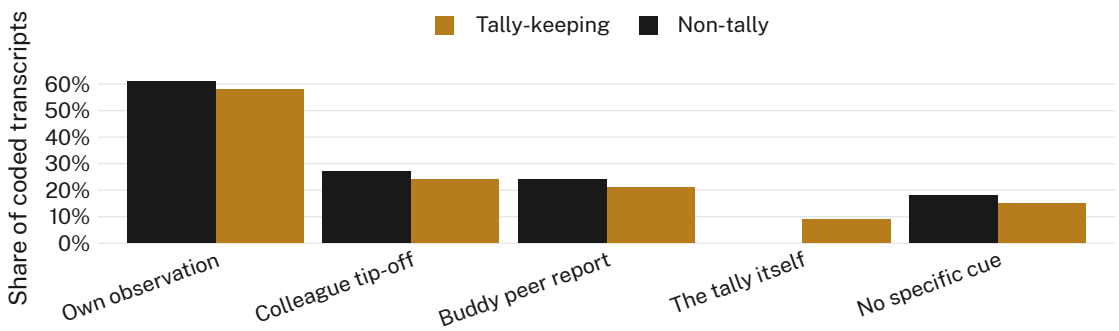
- Establish what playground supervisors report as their own trigger for flagging a child as newly included.
- Compare schools that keep a formal uptake tally against schools that don't.
- Test how often the tally itself, rather than a supervisor's own observation, is cited as that trigger.

Methods

- 48 supervisors · 19 primary schools (11 tally-keeping, 8 non-tally) · semi-structured interviews, 20-30 min
- Thematic coding (Braun & Clarke), double-coded, $\kappa = 0.78$
- Coding scheme fixed before interviews began; no post hoc categories added

Results

Supervisors at tally-keeping schools cite the tally itself as their trigger in under one in ten coded transcripts. The plurality trigger in both groups is an unprompted approach the supervisor says they would have caught regardless.



The tally itself was coded as the stated trigger in 9% of tally-school transcripts and, definitionally, 0% of non-tally transcripts; "own observation" led both groups within 3 points (58% vs 61%), interviews conducted Term 2, 2026.

Discussion & conclusions

The tally reaches the end-of-term report far more reliably than it reaches a supervisor's own account of noticing a child. Own-observation leads both groups almost identically, tally or no tally. Next: audit which specific report line each transcript's account actually supports.

References

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Interview protocol pre-registered; no pupil interviewed or named directly.

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“The tally made the report. The noticing happened somewhere else.”

Cited as the trigger in 9% of tally-school transcripts, Term 2 2026.